Aquifer Open Study Notes

This work is an adaptation of Tyndale Open Study Notes © 2023 Tyndale House Publishers, licensed under the CC BY-SA 4.0 license. The adaptation, Aquifer Open Study Notes, was created by Mission Mutual and is also licensed under CC BY-SA 4.0.

This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Romans

Romans 1:1

- a servant of Christ Jesus: The word servant describes key Old Testament leaders of God's people, such as:
- Moses (2 Kings 18:12),
- Joshua (Joshua 24:29),
- Elijah (2 Kings 10:10), and
- David (2 Samuel 7:8).

This title emphasizes the apostle Paul's total submission to Christ as Lord.

- set apart: Paul may be saying that God set him apart for his mission before he was born. This idea is similar to the call of the prophet Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:5). Paul may also be thinking about God's call during his conversion on the road to Damascus, when God chose him for a special task (Acts 9:15–16; compare Acts 13:2). God called Paul to preach the good news about Jesus to Jews and especially to Gentiles (non-Jews).
- The good news, also called "the gospel," appears many times at the beginning of this letter (Romans 1:1, 9, 15, 16). Paul takes the word gospel from the Old Testament. There, the Hebrew word refers to news of victory. It describes the victory God wins for his people and the hope he brings to them (Isaiah 40:9; 41:27; 60:6; 61:1; Nahum 1:15; see Joel 2:32).

Romans 1:1–17

These verses include typical features of New Testament letter introductions:

- identifying the writer or speaker (1:1–6),
- identifying the audience (1:7),
- a section of giving thanks (1:8–15), and
- the theme of the letter (1:16–17).

Romans 1:3

- According to the flesh: Paul often uses the word flesh (Greek sarx) to speak about bodily life in this world (for example, 4:1; 8:3).
- Paul mentions King David's family because God promised that a person descended from David would be the Messiah (God's chosen one) and would have an eternal kingdom (2 Samuel 7:13–16; see Isaiah 9:7; Jeremiah 33:15). Jesus was born into David's family line (Matthew 1:6; Luke 1:27, 32). This shows that he met God's requirement to fulfill this promise.

Romans 1:3–4

In the Greek text, these verses have a parallel structure. Paul might be quoting an early Christian statement of belief or a song about Jesus Christ as God's Son. He likely does this to show that they shared the same beliefs, since he had not yet visited them.

Romans 1:4

was declared with power to be: Although Jesus has existed forever as the Son of God, his resurrection demonstrated him to be God's Son, revealing him in all his power and glory. (1:3).

Romans 1:5

- received ... apostleship: The apostle Paul might be referring to both himself and the other apostles, or he might be using "we" to only refer to himself.
- we received grace and apostleship: Paul always makes it evident that his unique authority is a gift from God (see also 15:15–16).
- to the obedience that comes from faith: This summarizes Paul's goal in preaching to Gentiles (non-Jews). It frames the book of Romans, as he repeats the idea in different words at the end of the letter (16:26). Paul wanted Gentiles to trust in Jesus Christ. He emphasized that trusting in Jesus Christ as the Lord means committing to obey him. Faith and obeying are not the same, but one does not happen without the other.

Romans 1:7

be saints: This essentially means to be set apart for God. This expression appears throughout the Old Testament to describe Israel, God's people whom he chose (compare Exodus 19:6). God called Israel from among all other nations to belong to him. Paul calls the Gentile (non-Jewish) Christians "saints." Paul makes it plain that Gentiles who trust in Christ are now fully included among God's people.

Romans 1:9

with my spirit: This might mean God's Holy Spirit influences Paul's inner self. The word spirit also refers to the deepest part of a person.

Romans 1:11

some spiritual gift: Paul probably means the spiritual benefit he hopes his ministry will bring to the Roman Christians.

Romans 1:13

- brothers: The Greek word adelphoi describes people who are in a family relationship. Paul and other New Testament writers use this word to show that Christians belong to one family because they are united in Christ. The word refers to both male and female Christians.
- but have been prevented from visiting until now: Paul wrote this letter while in Corinth near the end of his third missionary journey (see Acts 20:2–4; compare Romans 16:21–23). Paul had been busy planting and supporting churches in the eastern Mediterranean. Before visiting the Roman Christians, he needed to return to Jerusalem to deliver money collected from the Gentile (non-Jewish) churches for the poor Jewish Christians (15:23–29).

Romans 1:14

to Greeks and non-Greeks: The Greeks were proud of being educated and cultured. They often thought people from other cultures were inferior. They mocked the way foreigners spoke Greek, saying it sounded like "bar bar," a meaningless sound. From this mockery comes the word barbarian (a person seen as uncivilized). Paul refers to this cultural divide to show that he wanted to preach the good news about Jesus to every kind of person.

Romans 1:16

The apostle Paul often emphasizes that the gospel (the good news about Jesus) is for everyone. He also insists that God first chose the Jews to be his people. God made promises to them and gave them a unique role in his continuing plan (3:1–8; 9:1–5). They have a special responsibility to respond to the gospel. They will experience God's judgment first if they reject the gospel (2:9–10).

Romans 1:17

- the righteousness of God: This important phrase appears eight times in Romans (see also 3:5, 21, 22, 25, 26; 10:3; the only other occurrence in Paul's writings is 2 Corinthians 5:21). In the Old Testament, God's righteousness refers to who God is (holy and faithful) and to what God does when he rescues his people and makes things right (see especially Isaiah 46:13; 51:5–8). Paul uses the second meaning in this verse. The gospel (the good news about Jesus) has the power to save because it fulfills God's promise to defend his people.
- "The righteous will live by faith": The prophet Habakkuk struggled to understand how God could use nations that worshiped false gods to judge his own people, Israel. God reminded Habakkuk that his true people were the righteous, who needed to live by faith (Habakkuk 2:4). In Romans 1–4, Paul often insists that only by faith can humans become right with God.

Romans 1:18

The wrath of God: God's wrath (or anger) is not a sudden emotional reaction. It is the holy God's necessary response to human sin. Because God is just and good, God must respond to what destroys life and faithfulness.

The Old Testament often describes God's wrath in specific historical events, such as Israel's rebellion or injustice among the people (Exodus 32:10–12; Numbers 11:1; Jeremiah 21:3–7). It also looks ahead to a future time when God will judge human sin in a final and decisive way.

Paul usually speaks of God's wrath as something that will happen at the end of history (Romans 2:5, 8; 5:9; Colossians 3:6; 1 Thessalonians 1:10). However, when Paul uses the present tense and says that God's wrath "is revealed," he points to God's actions in history as well. These passages show that God has already responded to sin throughout human history, not only at the end of time.

Romans 1:18–3.20

Paul waits to explain righteousness through faith (see 3:21) until he first teaches about the sinfulness of all people. Both non-Jews and Jews are equally under the power of sin (1:18–32; 2:1–3:8). Because of this, both groups are in the same situation before God. No one can gain God's favor by their own actions or obedience (3:9–20). All people need God's saving action, not their own efforts.

Romans 1:21

In Scripture, to know God usually means to have a close and saving relationship with him (see 2 Corinthians 5:16; Galatians 4:9; Philippians 3:8, 10). Here, however, they knew God means that people knew about God. All people have some understanding of God through creation, but they do not do what is right based on that knowledge. Instead of learning more about God, they worship gods they create themselves.

Romans 1:24

When people replaced the living God with idols (false gods), God abandoned them. Paul emphasizes this point twice more in this paragraph (1:26, 28). The

phrase gave them over suggests that God actively allows people to experience the consequences of their sin.

Romans 1:26

Even their women exchanged natural relations for unnatural ones: In this context, the natural way refers to the nature of the world as God made it.

As in the Old Testament, Paul refers to same-sex sexual behavior as one example of how people have turned away from honoring the true God (see Genesis 19:1–28; Leviticus 18:22; Leviticus 20:13; Deuteronomy 23:17–18).

God created human beings as male and female, and engaging in same-sex sexual activity is a violation of God's creative intention.

Romans 1:27

received in themselves the due penalty for their error: When people turn away from the Creator's purposes, God judges their actions. This judgment can happen in many ways, but the final result is spiritual death (see 1:32).

Romans 1:28

they did not see fit to acknowledge: Sin affects what people do and how they think. One serious result of turning away from God is an unsound mind. People can no longer think in the way God intended.

Romans 1:29–31

This list of sins follows a popular Hellenistic literary form called a vice list (a list that names sinful behaviors). The list does not include every sin, but it shows the many ways evil can appear.

Romans 1:32

To encourage others to sin is worse than sinning oneself (James 3:1; compare Testament of Asher 6:2: "The two-faced receive double punishment because they practice evil and approve of others who do the same; they imitate the spirits of error and join in the fight against humanity").

Romans 2:1–5

- You is singular in the Greek text. Here, you refers to a hypothetical Jew who feels superior to Gentiles and believes that he is not in danger of judgment. Paul uses a popular Hellenistic writing style called a diatribe (a teaching method that presents a debate with an imagined opponent). In this style, the writer argues against a made-up person in order to persuade the audience.
- the same things: Paul's means that Jews, like Gentiles, turn away from God's revelation and choose to follow their own path.

Romans 2:4

not realizing that God's kindness leads you to repentance?: Jewish writings describe a common attitude of false security about judgment (for example, Wisdom of Solomon 12–15; compare Jeremiah 7:1–5; Amos 5:18–27). Paul uses this idea when he asks his question. Many Jews believed that because they were God's people, they did not need to fear judgment. They thought their sins would not be punished in the same way as the sins of Gentiles. Paul makes clear that God's grace was meant to turn Jews away from sin, not to approve of a sinful way of life.

Romans 2:6–11

Paul uses a chiasm (a pattern shaped like an "X," where ideas are repeated in reverse order) to make his point:

- A God judges everyone the same (2:6)
- B Life is the reward for doing good (2:7)
- C Wrath is the penalty for evil (2:8)
- C′ Wrath for doing evil (2:9)
- B′ Life for doing good (2:10)
- A' God shows no favoritism (2:11)

Romans 2:7

To those ... doing good ... He will give eternal life: Paul explains elsewhere that no one can receive eternal life except as God's gift through faith (3:20, 28; 4:1–8). Here, Paul may be speaking about Christians whose good actions come from faith and will be considered in God's judgment. Or he may be pointing to God's perfect standard of holiness, which shows that only complete perfection could bring acceptance before God. As Paul's argument continues, he shows that no one is able to meet this standard.

Romans 2:8

self-seeking: This phrase translates a rare Greek word, eritheia, which means selfish ambition or strife. The Greek philosopher Aristotle used this word to criticize politicians of his time. He said they pursued public office for personal gain instead of wanting to serve the people (Aristotle, Politics 5.3; see also 2 Corinthians

12:20; Galatians 5:20; Philippians 1:17; 2:3; James 3:14, 16).

Romans 2:12

- Perish: This common New Testament word describes the final outcome of the wicked after judgment (see also 9:22; 14:15; 1 Corinthians 1:18; 15:18; 2 Corinthians 2:15; 4:3; Philippians 1:28; 3:19; 2 Thessalonians 2:10; 1 Timothy 6:9). It refers to complete ruin and loss under God's judgment.
- all ... under the law: The Jews received the law of Moses, while the Gentiles (non-Jewish people) never had God's written law. In the New Testament period, Jews saw having the law as a mark of God's favor towards them and even as a guarantee of salvation.

Romans 2:13

the doers of the law who will be declared righteous: Regarding the promise of righteousness through obedience, see 2:7 and James 1:22.

Romans 2:14–15

Gentiles, who do not have the law, do by nature what the law requires: This fits with the idea that the law is written on their hearts (2:15), which points to the promise of the new covenant (Jeremiah 31:31–34).

Or Paul may be speaking about non-Christian Gentiles. These Gentiles know God's basic moral law through their conscience. In this case, Paul shows that all people can be held responsible for basic moral standards, even without God's written law.

Romans 2:16

secrets (literally the hidden things): Scripture often emphasizes that God will judge people based on their thoughts and intentions (see 1 Samuel 16:7; Psalm 139:1–2; Jeremiah 17:10).

Romans 2:17–20

The pride of the Jews reflects Old Testament and Jewish teachings about the privileges and responsibilities God gave to Israel. God gave his law to Israel, formed a special relationship with them, and gave them the task of being a spiritual light to the Gentiles (see Isaiah 42:6–7). Jews were not wrong to enjoy these blessings; their error was in failing to live up to their privileged position.

Romans 2:21–22

Paul again uses the diatribe style (a teaching method that argues with an imagined opponent) to show the inconsistency in Jewish claims (see study note on 2:1–5).

Romans 2:22

do you rob temples?: Old Testament law prohibited Jews from having anything to do with pagan idols (see Deuteronomy 7:26). Pagans were those who worshiped false gods, and idols were hand-made representations of these false gods. But first-century AD Jews did not always follow this law. Sometimes they stole idols and used or sold the valuable metals from which the pagans made the idols.

Romans 2:24

Paul quotes Isaiah 52:5, where God's name is blasphemed because Israel is oppressed by pagan nations. Here, Paul uses that passage to demonstrate the failure of the Jews to live up to their responsibilities.

Romans 2:25

God established the Jewish ceremony of circumcision as a sign of his covenant (special agreement) with Abraham. God required that every male Israelite child be circumcised (Genesis 17:9–13; see Romans 4:11). Circumcision represents God's covenant with his people, Israel.

The ceremony became more important during the intertestamental period (the time between the Old and New Testaments). During this time, the pagan king Antiochus IV Epiphanes tried to destroy the Jewish faith. He did this by forbidding circumcision and other Jewish practices.

The Jews resisted him in the Maccabean Revolt (166–160 BC). After they restored worship of the Lord in Israel, the Jews viewed circumcision as a valued sign of loyalty to God while living among pagan peoples.

Romans 2:26

will not his uncircumcision be regarded as circumcision?: Paul might be referring to Gentile Christians who are God's people because they follow God's law. Alternatively, he could be speaking in an imaginary way about what would happen if a non-Jew perfectly obeyed God's law.

Romans 2:29

the written code: This refers to God's law written on tablets of stone (see 2 Corinthians 3:3). Now the Holy Spirit writes God's law on people's hearts, meaning that God places his law within them and changes how they think and live (Jeremiah 31:33–34). This contrast

shows the difference between obeying rules only on the outside and obeying God because he has changed a person's inner life.

Romans 3:1

What, then, is the advantage of being a Jew?: Paul advances his argument by asking questions. After preaching the gospel (the good news about Jesus) for over twenty years, he knew what questions people would ask when they heard a specific teaching. His focus on the equality of Jews and non-Jews (Gentiles) before God (chapter 2) naturally invited people to ask if he was removing all Jewish privileges. The question-and-answer style follows the pattern of the diatribe style. In this method, a speaker asks questions and then answers them to correct or guide the listener (see study note on 2:1–5).

Romans 3:2

- The Jews had the advantage of receiving words of God.
- First of all: Paul does not add a second or third point to his list. He might have forgotten to continue, or first of all might mean "most importantly." However, 9:4–5 suggests what a list of Jewish privileges might include.
- By using the phrase very words (Greek logia, meaning "oracles" or "messages"), Paul emphasizes God's personal communication with his people (see Deuteronomy 33:9; Psalm 105:19). Through this, God gives them special privileges and responsibilities.

Romans 3:4

- Certainly not!: The Greek phrase mē genoito is a strong way to say "no." Paul often uses this style of argument in other parts of Romans (see 3:6, 31; 6:2, 15; 7:7, 13; 9:14; 11:1, 11).
- As it is written: Paul quotes Psalm 51:4, where King David admitted his sin of committing adultery with Bathsheba (see 2 Samuel 11:1–27). God punished David, and David admitted that God was right to judge him. David accepted that God's judgment was completely just.

God remains faithful to everything he has said in the past. This includes his whole revelation. God's words warn people about punishment for sin, but they also promise blessing for obedience.

Romans 3:5–7

how could God judge the world?: Abraham asked a similar question: "Will not the Judge of all the earth do what is right?" (Genesis 18:25). God punishes all sin and maintains absolute righteousness while doing so. Even when God makes use of human sin for his own ends, that sin still deserves to be, and will be, punished (see Romans 9:10–24).

Romans 3:8

some slanderously claim that we say: Paul is referring to misrepresentations about his teaching on justification by faith. If a person is made right with God by faith alone, through God's grace and apart from works, it could seem as if the gospel allows Christians to sin because God forgives their sin when they confess it (see 6:1). One of Paul's purposes is to help the Roman Christians understand that such misunderstandings are without basis.

Romans 3:9

- Not at all: Paul's strong response does not contradict his earlier statement in 3:1–2 that Jews have an advantage. However, this advantage has not benefited them because they did not obey God's commands and encountered God's punishment. Jews, like Gentiles (here, Greeks), have sinned against the revelation of God and stand condemned.
- under sin: Being "under" something means it controls a person. The main problem for humans is not only that they have sin, but they are slaves of sin. The solution to this problem is the freedom that Christ Jesus provides. He frees people from both the penalty and the power of sin.

Romans 3:10–12

This quotation from Psalms 14:1–3; 53:1–3 directly supports the argument that all people are under the power of sin.

Romans 3:10–18

The six quotations in these verses come from different parts of the Old Testament. All of them speak about human sinfulness.

Paul follows a teaching practice used by Jewish teachers. They gathered several Old Testament passages that shared the same theme and placed them together. This method is sometimes called pearl-stringing (linking texts one after another to make a single point).

Romans 3:13–14

Paul here speaks about sins of speech. In each of the four lines, he mentions a different part of the body used for speaking.

Romans 3:15–17

This quotation from Isaiah 59:7–8 discusses sins committed against others.

Romans 3:18

There is no: This concluding quotation from Psalm 36:1 effectively summarizes the entire series (Romans 3:10–18). It uses the same Greek words, ouk estin, that begin the first quotation. In Romans 3:10, the phrase is translated "There is no one."

Romans 3:19

- Paul refers to the entire Old Testament as the law (see also 1 Corinthians 9:8, 9; 14:21, 34; Galatians 4:21).
- The Jews, who received the Scriptures, were those to whom God gave the law (literally, those in the law).
- How can Paul conclude that the whole world [is] held accountable to God based on Old Testament evidence that Jews are sinful? He uses a common Jewish technique of argument, reasoning from the greater idea to the lesser. The law shows that the Jews, the people God chose, are accountable. So, the non-Jews (Gentiles), who did not receive God's instruction, are even more accountable.

Romans 3:20

by works of the law: This means obeying the rules given by Moses, the prophet and leader of Israel. While this phrase refers to Jews, the principle extends to all people. If Jews cannot be put in right relationship with God by obeying the law God gave them, certainly other people cannot establish such a relationship through good deeds.

Romans 3:21–22

- After a long discussion about the power of sin (1:18–3:20), Paul returns to the main idea in 1:17, which is how to be in a right relationship with God (literally the righteousness of God). In 1:17, "the righteousness of God" is the way that God puts people in right relationship with himself.
- apart from the law: The old covenant looked ahead to God's righteousness being revealed in his Son, Jesus Christ. Through Christ, God fulfilled the law for us. Because of what God has accomplished for us in Christ by completely fulfilling the requirements of the law, we are now able to come to him by faith, apart from the covenant structure set up by the law of Moses (see Hebrews 8:13).

Romans 3:21–4.25

Paul returns to the central theme of God's righteousness. This righteousness is revealed in Jesus Christ and is available to anyone who believes.

Paul states this teaching most clearly in 3:21–26. Paul explains it further in 3:27–31. He then shows how it works by using the experience of Abraham in chapter 4.

Romans 3:24

- by His grace: God places us in a right relationship with him, not because he must, but because God chooses to give us his favor through Christ Jesus. Because we are helpless slaves of sin (3:9), our righteous status before God can never be earned (see 4:4–5).
- through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus: In Paul's day, redemption referred to the price paid to free a slave. God paid our redemption price with the blood of his own Son to rescue us from our slavery to sin (see 3:9). TThis language was used in the Old Testament to refer to the exodus from Egypt, the first redemption of God's people from slavery (see 2 Samuel 7:23). God promised that he would again redeem his people (Hosea 13:14; Micah 4:10).

Romans 3:25

- As an atoning sacrifice (Greek hilastērion): This Greek word appears in the Greek Old Testament. It refers to the atonement cover, the lid placed on the ark of the covenant inside the most sacred room of the tabernacle. This cover played a central role in the Day of Atonement ceremony (Leviticus 16). Over time, the word came to represent the atonement ritual itself.

Paul uses this word to describe Jesus Christ. God provided Jesus as the final sacrifice for sin. Through Jesus, God deals fully with human sin. Jesus bears God's righteous anger against sin himself (see Romans 1:18).

- the sins committed beforehand: Paul refers to faithful people in the Old Testament period whose sins were not punished as strict justice would require. The letter to the Hebrews explains that animal sacrifices could not truly remove sin (Hebrews 10:4).

So how could God forgive people before Christ? Paul explains that Jesus's sacrifice works both backward and forward in time. Through Christ, God fully satisfied his righteous judgment against human sin for all people.

Romans 3:29–30

Paul builds his argument on the Jewish belief that there is only one God. From this belief, he shows that God offers forgiveness to all people.

If there is only one God, then he is the God of both Jews and Gentiles. Because of this, all people must be able to come to God in the same way. They come to him through faith.

Romans 3:31

Instead, we uphold the law: Paul knows that some people will object to his teaching about faith apart from the law. It may sound as if he is setting aside the law's demands.

However, faith does not cancel the law. Faith makes it possible for people to live as the law requires. God gives the Holy Spirit to those who have faith, and the Spirit enables them to do what is right.

Romans 4:1

Jews in Paul's time honored Abraham as the founder of Israel. Some Jewish writings even claim that Abraham never sinned (Prayer of Manasseh 8; Jubilees 23:10). Other writings stress his obedience and connect his relationship with God to keeping the law of Moses (1 Maccabees 2:52; Sirach 44:19–20).

Paul argues differently. He shows that Abraham's faith, not his obedience to the law, is what put him in a right relationship with God. Because Abraham is the founder of God's people, his example shows that being made right with God by faith stands at the center of God's plan.

Romans 4:3

Paul quotes Genesis 15:6. In response to God's promise that his descendants would be as numerous as the stars in the sky, Abraham trusted God. It was faith that established Abraham's relationship with God.

This relationship did not come from works, circumcision, the law, or the number of his descendants (Romans 4:3–21).

Romans 4:4–5

The logic of these verses is as follows:

1. When people work, their pay is what they earn, not a gift.
2. The idea not stated is that God never owes his creatures anything. They owe him everything. So, anything he gives is a gift (see also 9:14–16).
3. The conclusion is that God does not place people in a right relationship with him because of their works.

Romans 4:7–8

This quotation from Psalm 32:1–2 follows the Jewish tradition of supporting a reference to the law with one from the prophets or writings. Paul also uses a Jewish way of interpreting Scripture. This method links different quotations by repeating a key word. Here, count translates the same Greek word as "credited" in Romans 4:3.

Romans 4:10

God accepted Abraham before circumcision. Paul's point is simple: God "credited" Abraham as righteous in Genesis 15:6 before his circumcision, which happened later (Genesis 17). This shows that God's acceptance and blessing are free gifts, not earned by works of the law.

Romans 4:11–12

When God introduced circumcision, he called it "a sign of the covenant" between himself and Abraham (Genesis 17:11). The covenant existed before Abraham became circumcised (Genesis 12:1–3; 15:1–21; 17:1–8). This shows that it was on the basis of faith, not circumcision. Therefore, Abraham is the spiritual father of all people, whether circumcised (Jews) or uncircumcised (Gentiles), "who are of the faith of Abraham" (Romans 4:13–25).

Romans 4:13

of the world: God told Abraham that he would be the father of many nations (4:17; Genesis 12:2; 13:16; 15:5; 17:4–6, 16–20; 22:17). God also said Abraham would bring blessings to all people (Genesis 12:3; 18:18; 22:18; compare Isaiah 55:3–5).

Romans 4:14

faith is useless (literally faith has become empty): If works of the law could replace faith, then faith would lose its importance. Trusting in God means recognizing our need and relying completely on God's mercy, which leads to a life of obedience.

Romans 4:15

where there is no law, neither is there transgression: Paul always uses the word transgression to mean not obeying a plain commandment of God (see also 2:23; 5:14; Galatians 3:19; 1 Timothy 2:14). So, transgression can only exist where the law exists. This is why violat-

ing the law always brings punishment. The law that God gave to the Israelites had detailed requirements. This made the people more accountable for sin than before their law existed. When they inevitably violated this law, God punished them more severely.

Romans 4:16

not only to those who are of the law: The Jews were of the law in that their covenant with God included the law of Moses and they were to live according to it.

Romans 4:24

raised ... from the dead: Abraham experienced the life-giving power of God in the birth of his son Isaac. Christians witness it in the resurrection of Jesus. Throughout history, salvation has been available only through faith in God, who makes and keeps his promises.

Romans 5:1

- We have peace: In many manuscripts, the Greek verb states a fact. This form means "we have peace" and presents peace as something believers already possess. Other manuscripts use a different verb form that expresses an appeal or encouragement. In that case, the meaning would be "let us have peace."
- Peace with God does not mean only a feeling of calm. It describes a real situation. When people believe in Jesus Christ, hostility between God and sinful human beings comes to an end. This peace also includes the blessing and salvation God promised his people in the future (see Isaiah 9:6–7; 52:7; Ezekiel 34:25; Nahum 1:15).

Romans 5:1–8.39

Paul now moves from the good news about how people begin a relationship with God to the security of that relationship. Christians have a strong and lasting promise. This promise rests on God's work in Jesus Christ, God's love for them, and the power of the Holy Spirit.

This promise shapes the teaching in these chapters (5:1–11; 8:18–39). Paul explains it by showing that believers have been moved from the realm of Adam to the realm of Christ (5:12–21). Because of this change, no power can break this relationship. Sin (chapter 6), the law (chapter 7), or death (8:1–13) cannot separate believers from God's love (8:39).

Romans 5:2

- Grace: God's grace (Greek charis) is so central that Paul uses this word to describe our whole life as believers. Grace does not only begin the Christian life. Believers continue to depend on God's grace every day.
- in which we stand: This indicates that we need God's grace throughout the Christian life, not just at the beginning.
- Sharing God's glory describes the hope believers have for the future. Paul introduces this hope here and explains it more fully later (8:18–30). When Paul speaks about glory (Greek doxa), he bases his meaning on the Hebrew word kabod (which means "weight, honor, powerful presence"). This word describes God's majesty and overwhelming presence. The prophets looked forward to a future time when God's glory would return and live among his people (see, for example, Isaiah 60:1–2).

Romans 5:3–4

See also James 1:2–4; 1 Peter 1:6–7. The similarities in these passages indicate early Christian teaching common to all three of these writers.

Romans 5:5

- hope does not disappoint (literally does not put to shame): In the Old Testament, shame sometimes means that God has judged someone as guilty (for example, Isaiah 28:16, quoted in Romans 9:33).
- has poured out His love into our hearts through the Holy Spirit: See Jeremiah 31:33–34; Acts 2:17–21.

Romans 5:6

at just the right time: This could mean God sent Christ at a specific historical moment. It could also mean our totally vulnerable spiritual condition was the perfect time for God to demonstrate his love by sending his Son on our behalf.

Romans 5:9

- The blood of Christ refers to the sacrificial death of Jesus (3:25). In the Scriptures, blood often means a violent death, especially when that death "makes atonement" for sins (Leviticus 17:11).
- how much more shall we be saved from wrath through Him!: Paul often describes salvation as the final rescue of Christians from God's wrath and life's troubles (see Romans 13:11).

Romans 5:10

saved through His life: Christians already share in the new life that Christ provided through his resurrection (6:11). Because believers are joined to Christ, God will

spare them from his final judgment on the last day (see also Colossians 3:4).

Romans 5:12

- Adam is both the name of the first man and a Hebrew word that means "human." Paul emphasizes Adam's connection with the human race.
- sin entered the world: The importance Paul gives to this act, and the way he compares Adam's sin with Christ's obedience on the cross, shows that Paul understood Adam and the sin in the garden of Eden as real events in history.
- all sinned: Death affects everyone because sin affects everyone. It is uncertain when or how all sinned. But Paul later attributes the condemnation of all people to the sin of Adam, their representative (5:18).
- Jewish tradition is not united on how Adam's sin relates to the sin and death of all human beings. Different Jewish texts explain this relationship in different ways.

Some texts teach a strong connection between Adam and all other people. These writings say that Adam's sin brought death to the whole human family. One example says, "when Adam sinned, a death was decreed for those yet to be born" (2 Baruch 23:4). Other texts place responsibility on each individual person. These writings say that people die because of their own sin, not because of Adam's sin. One text states, "Adam is not the cause, except for himself; each of us has become our own Adam" (2 Baruch 54:19).

Romans 5:13–14

Paul continues his explanation of "all sinned"(5:12) by stating that people who died between the times of Adam and Moses were not subject to specific commandments from God. Therefore, their condemnation was not only because of their own sin. It was because of their union with Adam, who sinned by violating a clear commandment of God.

Romans 5:15

Paul uses the word many to contrast with one. Many does not always mean all, but it can include everyone if the context suggests it. In this passage, the many who suffer death because of Adam clearly includes everyone (see 5:12). However, Paul explains elsewhere that the many who receive the gift of forgiveness through Jesus Christ does not include everyone (see 11:1–5).

Romans 5:17

Both Adam and Jesus Christ performed a single act whose effects reach all the people they represent. Adam represents all people. To be represented by Christ, people must receive the gift of righteousness.

Romans 5:18

- Christ's one act of righteousness refers to his death on the cross, a righteous act because Christ chose to die in obedience to the Father's will (see John 10:18).
- life for all men: Paul is not teaching that all people will experience the new life that Christ won through his death on the cross. New life is available to everyone through Christ, but not everyone receives it.

Romans 5:20

Many Jews believed that God's law, given to Israel, reversed or reduced the harmful effects of Adam's sin. Paul says instead that God's law caused sin to increase and helped people see their sin more clearly.

Romans 6:1

What then: Because Paul has just proclaimed that God multiplies grace where sin increases (5:20), he knows that people will wonder whether this means that sin does not matter in the Christian life.

Romans 6:2

we who died to sin: Paul explains in 6:3–10 our new relationship to sin is possible because we are closely connected to the death of Jesus. Just as dying means entrance into an entirely new state of being, our relationship with sin is now different because of Christ's death.

To be dead to sin does not mean that believers no longer feel temptation or desire to sin. Believers are still involved in a struggle against sin (6:12–14). However, Christians no longer have to live as helpless slaves to sin. Because of Christ's death, they are able to choose not to sin (6:6, 14, 16–22).

Romans 6:3

Baptism is the ceremony that initiates a person into the Christian faith (see Acts 2:38, 41). It sometimes represents the whole conversion experience. Paul describes baptism as the way Christians unite to Christ in his death and resurrection (see also Romans 6:4). However, baptism has no value apart from faith.

Romans 6:4

We were therefore buried with Christ: The Christian's power over sin and ability to lead a new life come from union with Christ's death, burial, and resurrection (see 6:5, 8). From God's perspective, because Jesus died to sin, Christians have as well (see 6:10). The resurrection of Jesus means we also start a new life, and in the future, our bodies will also be raised.

Romans 6:6

our old self: Our "old self" is not only a part of us. It represents who we were in spiritual union with Adam. All humans were born "in Adam." As those who inherit the effects of sin and death he brought into the world, humans became slaves to sin's power (5:12).

Now, however, we are in Christ. We have shared in his death on the cross (see also Galatians 2:20). When he died on the cross, the old self of Christians also died to the power of sin that once controlled them.

Romans 6:8

we will also live with him: This means we will experience a resurrection of our bodies with Christ (see 6:5). Christians are already spiritually resurrected with Christ (Ephesians 2:5–6; Colossians 2:13). We will also experience a physical resurrection when he returns in glory (2 Corinthians 4:14; Philippians 3:21; 1 Thessalonians 4:17; 2 Timothy 2:11).

Romans 6:10

He died to sin once for all: Because Christians spiritually died with Jesus, we have also died to sin (6:4–5; 6:2). Jesus was never under sin's power like we were, because he did not inherit the effects of sin from Adam and never committed sin (2 Corinthians 5:21; Hebrews 4:15). However, when he became human, he entered a world where sin has power. In this human life, he was truly able to be tempted by sin.

Romans 6:14

- You are not under law: With the coming of Christ, the period ruled by the law of Moses came to an end (see Galatians 3:19–25).
- under grace: God has always acted toward his people with grace. However, grace now rules the new era in which Christians live in Christ. Compare John 1:17.

Romans 6:15

we are not under law: The law of Moses ruled the period of the old covenant. Christians now live under the rule of Christ himself.

Romans 6:16

righteousness (Greek dikaiosunē): In the first part of Romans, Paul uses this Greek word in a legal sense. It refers either to God's action of placing people in a right relationship with himself or to the right standing believers receive because of Christ's work (see, for example, 1:17; 3:21–22; 4:3, 5).

Here, Paul uses the same word in the way it is often used in the Old Testament. It means the right kind of behavior that God expects from his people.

Romans 6:19

Paul uses the Greek word sarx (human nature, or flesh) to describe human weakness and the tendency to sin. Paul uses the illustration of slavery to show the relationship of the human nature to sin.

Romans 6:20

free from the obligation to righteousness (literally free from righteousness): Paul means either that unbelievers feel no obligation to obey God or that they are unable to do so. But the freedom that they boast of actually makes them slaves to sin.

Romans 6:21

death: Throughout chapters 5–8, Paul uses death to describe the eternal consequences of sin (5:12, 14, 15, 17, 21; 6:16, 23; 7:5, 9–10, 13, 24; 8:2, 6, 13). This language refers back to God's warning to Adam and Eve (Genesis 2:17). This death is not mainly physical. It means human separation from God's fellowship or union with God. If not reversed through faith in Christ and, it will last forever.

Romans 7:1

- Both Jewish Christians and many Gentile Christians were familiar with the law. Jewish people were taught the law of Moses from birth. Many Gentiles in the church at Rome had previously been God-fearers. These were Gentiles who were interested in Judaism and regularly attended the synagogue.
- the law has authority over a man only as long as he lives: Paul might be referencing a well-known Jewish saying. One rabbinic tradition says, "If a person is dead, he is free from the Torah and the fulfilling

of the commandments" (Babylonian Shabbat 30a; baraita Shabbat 151).

Romans 7:2–3

These verses are not an allegory, in which every part of the story has a separate theological meaning. Paul uses a simple illustration to make two main points:

1. Death can free a person from the law.
2. Ending one relationship can allow a person to start a new one.

Paul applies this example in 7:4.

Romans 7:4

died to the law: This means they are no longer bound by it. Paul often describes the law of Moses as representing the old system of sin and death. However, through their union with Christ in his death, Christians are set free.

Romans 7:5

- the flesh: The word flesh can sometimes refer to the human body in a neutral way. For example, Paul speaks of Christ coming "in the flesh" (see 8:3). More often, however, Paul uses flesh in a negative sense. It describes human life lived apart from God. To live according to the flesh means to be ruled by sin and opposed to God.
- the sinful passions aroused by the law: God's law is good in itself (see 7:12). However, because people have sinful hearts (inner desires that go against God), the law can cause sinful desires to appear. When people live in rebellion against God, his commands can cause a desire to do the opposite of what he commands.

Romans 7:6

the written code (literally the letter): Paul uses this phrase to refer to the law of Moses. God carved this law on stone tablets consisting of individual letters (see 2:29; 2 Corinthians 3:5–7).

Romans 7:7–25

What then (see study note on 6:1): Paul has just spoken in strong terms about the law. Now he explains that God's law is good. He does this to prevent people from thinking that the law itself is evil.

Romans 7:8

- Sin, seizing its opportunity through the commandment: The word opportunity is a military term for a position seized in enemy territory that becomes a base of operations (see 7:11). By expressing God's demands, the commandments provoke rebellion within people controlled by sin. God's commandments become a chance for sin to achieve its harmful goals.
- apart from the law, sin is dead: The law, by plainly expressing God's will, makes people more accountable than they would be without it. The law of Moses did not solve Israel's sin problem but revealed and made it worse. This is always the effect that God's law, by itself, has on people controlled by sin.

Romans 7:9

- Once I was alive apart from the law: Paul might be referring to his early childhood, before he fully understood the law's demands.
- but when the commandment came: Paul's experience with the law as he matured reflects everyone's experience. With the law, we have more accountability to God. This gives sin power and leads to greater judgment (7:10; see 4:15; 5:14, 20).

Romans 7:10

The Old Testament promised a blessed and secure life to those who obeyed the law (for example, Leviticus 18:5, quoted in Romans 10:5). However, people inherit a strong tendency to sin because of the effects of Adam's sin. So, when God's commands come to us, we often resist and disobey them. So, instead of bringing life, the law only reveals our lost and vulnerable spiritual condition. We need God to change our desires because the law cannot provide this inner change.

Romans 7:11

sin ... deceived me: Paul uses language similar to Genesis 3:13. He may be thinking about the first human disobedience.

Romans 7:17

it is no longer I who do it: Paul is not avoiding responsibility for his sin (see also 7:20). Instead, he explains that he truly wants to do what the law commands. Because of this, something else must be causing him to act in the opposite way. That cause is sin living in him. Paul describes a conflict between what he wants to do and what he actually does.

Romans 7:18

in my flesh: See study note on 6:19. This phrase may refer to Paul's former life before God redeemed him. It may also refer to a part of Paul that is still connected to this world and resists God's will.

Romans 7:21

the principle (literally law): Paul is referring to something that happens again and again. The struggle between wanting to do what is right and doing what is wrong shows a repeated pattern in human life.

Romans 7:22

in my inner being: Greek writers used this phrase to refer to the inner life of a person. It points to the spiritual part of a human being that does not pass away (compare 2 Corinthians 4:16; Ephesians 3:16).

Romans 7:23

another law ... the law: Paul uses the word play with law in these verses (7:22). Opposing God's law is another law, a ruling power that stops Paul from following God's law, even though he fully agrees with it.

Romans 7:24

this body of death: Sin affects the whole person. It especially shapes how people live and act in the physical world.

Romans 8:1

Therefore, there is now no condemnation: Paul concludes from the arguments in chapters 5–7 that neither sin nor the law can prevent Christians from gaining eternal life.

Paul confidently declares that people who belong to Christ Jesus do not need to fear condemnation for their sins.

Romans 8:2

the law of the Spirit of life: This reference to law might refer to the law of Moses, which the Holy Spirit can use to give life. However, Paul does not describe the law as giving life. So, here, law, as in 7:23, probably means principle or power. The Spirit has power that frees Christians from the power of sin that leads to death.

Romans 8:3

- the flesh: See study note on 6:19.
- in the likeness of sinful man: Jesus fully shared human flesh and life in a world ruled by sin. He identified with sinful people so that he could act as their representative. At the same time, he did not himself commit sin.
- an offering for sin: In the Greek Old Testament, this phrase frequently describes a sin offering, and three of the eight New Testament occurrences also have this meaning (Hebrews 10:6, 8; 13:11). Christ was the sin offering that brought forgiveness and turned away God's wrath against sin. God judged sin in Christ, our substitute (the one who took our place), so that we could escape judgment.

Romans 8:4

- the righteous standard of the law ... might be fulfilled in us. The Greek preposition en ("in") can be understood in more than one way. It may mean that the law is fulfilled in us because we are united with Jesus Christ, who fully obeyed the law for us. It can also mean that, by freeing us from the power of sin, Jesus Christ enables us to please God and live out the true purpose of the law.
- In the Old Testament, the flesh refers to human weakness and slavery to sin (see Genesis 6:3, 12; Psalm 78:39; Isaiah 40:6; also in Romans 8:5–9, 12–13). Paul uses this phrase to describe the conflict between the human tendency to sin and the Holy Spirit.

Romans 8:5

set their minds on the things of the flesh: This phrase refers to a person's overall intentions, not just their thoughts (see also 12:3; 15:5; Philippians 2:2, 5).

Romans 8:6

Peace here does not just mean peace of mind. Instead, it means being at peace with God, as opposed to death (see study note on 5:1).

Romans 8:9

You ... are controlled ... by the Spirit: In contrast to unbelievers, who still live under the rule of Adam's sinful nature, Christians are guided in their lives by the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit does not remove human choice or make Christians unable to sin. However, as the strongest influence in the lives of Christians, the Spirit makes it possible for them to resist the ongoing power of sin.

Romans 8:10

your spirit is alive: Because the Holy Spirit lives in believers, their spirit has life, even though their body is subject to death because of sin. The Spirit stands against sin, which leads to death, and guarantees future resurrection from the dead.

Romans 8:11

through His Spirit: The Holy Spirit is the one who raises believers' bodies from the dead. Some manuscripts read "because of his Spirit." This wording would mean that the Spirit living in believers is the guarantee that their bodies will be raised (compare Ephesians 1:14).

Romans 8:13

you will die: Death is the result of sin. Those who consistently submit to sin will suffer spiritual death (you will die). However, the presence of the Holy Spirit in the lives of Christians makes it possible for them to turn away from sin. The result is eternal life (you will live).

Romans 8:14

sons of God: In the Old Testament, this phrase referred to Israel, the people God called to be his own (see especially Exodus 4:22; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9; Hosea 11:1). Paul uses it to remind believers that they have a close relationship with God and that they will inherit many of the promises and blessings given to Israel. Christians are no longer minors or slaves, but mature children with full rights (see Galatians 4:1–7).

Romans 8:15

- you received the Spirit of adoption to sonship: According to Greco-Roman customs of adoption, a man could adopt a son and give that child the same legal rights as a natural son. This practice included the highest levels of society, even the imperial family. For example, the Roman ruler Julius Caesar adopted Octavian as his heir. Octavian later ruled the Roman Empire under the name Augustus.

Paul's understanding of adoption is also rooted in the Old Testament and Jewish tradition. In the Scriptures, God describes Israel as his child and shows care, guidance, and discipline like a parent (Exodus 4:22; Deuteronomy 1:31; Hosea 11:1; see also Romans 9:4; Galatians 4:5; Ephesians 1:5).

- Abba: This word was used within close family relationships and expressed deep trust and affection (similar to "dear father"). Jesus used this word when speaking to God (Mark 14:36). Through Jesus, all who become children of God are given the same privilege of addressing God in this personal way.

Romans 8:17

Jesus is heir to all of God's promises (Mark 12:1–12; Galatians 3:18–19; Hebrews 1:2). As those who belong to Jesus, we share with him in that glorious inheritance. However, just as it was for Jesus, our path to glory is also marked by suffering. We experience challenges while trying to live right in a world dominated by sin (2 Corinthians 1:5; Philippians 1:29; 3:10).

Romans 8:19–21

- creation: This includes animals, plants, and the earth itself. Paul follows the pattern found in the Old Testament by speaking about creation as if it were a person (see especially Psalm 65:12–13; Isaiah 24:4; Jeremiah 4:28; 12:4).
- waits in eager expectation for: Just as Adam's sin brought harm to the whole created world, creation will also share in the blessings God has promised to his people. This hope includes the renewal of the earth itself (for example, Isaiah 4:2, Revelation 21:1–2).

Romans 8:22

the pains of childbirth: This is a metaphor for the eager waiting of creation (see also Matthew 24:8; Mark 13:8; John 16:20–22).

Romans 8:23

- we ourselves ... groan: The word groan describes a deep and frustrated longing for God to rescue us from the suffering and oppression of this life (see Exodus 3:7; Lamentations 1:22; Ezekiel 24:17; 2 Corinthians 5:2).
- who have the firstfruits of the Spirit: In the Old Testament, first harvest or firstfruits refers to offering the first and best part of a crop to God (see Exodus 23:19; Leviticus 2:12; 23:10; compare 1 Corinthians 15:20, 23). In the same way, the Holy Spirit is God's promise that he will finish the work he has begun in us (see Ephesians 1:14).
- Although God has already adopted believers as his children, we do not yet enjoy all the rights of that adoption. Our inheritance is still in the future (see Romans 8:17). In this life, Christians live between what God has already done and what he will fully reveal in the future.

Romans 8:26

groans too deep for words: This may refer to prayer that does not use normal human language. In such moments, believers may not know what to say and may only cry out to God without clear words.

These groanings belong to the Holy Spirit, not to believers themselves. When believers do not know how to pray, the Holy Spirit prays for them and speaks to God on their behalf.

Romans 8:30

He also glorified: Elsewhere in this passage, the glory Christians will experience is always in the future (8:18, 21, 23). The past tense refers to a decision God has already made. God has decided in the past that he will glorify us in the future.

Christians have not yet received their full inheritance. However, the Father has firmly and permanently decided to share his glory with us.

Romans 8:31

Paul is referring to everything he has taught in chapters 5–8 about the blessings and sense of assurance that believers receive from their relationship with God.

Romans 8:32

He who did not spare His own Son: This language recalls the story of Abraham, who was willing to offer his son Isaac to God (Genesis 22:12, 16). However, Isaac was not actually sacrificed.

In contrast, God did not hold back his only Son. He allowed Jesus to be handed over and to suffer a shameful and painful death on the cross.

Romans 9:1–11.36

n this section, Paul addresses a serious question. Many Jews did not believe in Jesus. If God had promised salvation to Israel, how could Jesus truly fulfill God's plan when so few Jews believed (9:1–5)? In response, Paul uses the Old Testament to show that God always planned to save only a remnant, that is, a smaller group within Israel (9:6–29). Paul also explains that many Jews did not accept Christ because they refused to trust in him (9:30–10:21).

Paul then makes clear that God has not rejected Israel. Some Jews have already believed in Christ (11:1–10). Many more will trust in Christ in the future (11:12–26).

Romans 9:2–3

Paul does not clearly explain why he feels such deep sorrow for his Jewish brothers and sisters. However, he says that he would be willing to be cursed for their sake if it would save them.

This shows that his pain comes from the fact that most Jews did not accept Jesus and be saved (see also 10:1).

Romans 9:3

I could wish that I myself were cursed: The Greek word anathema is used in the Greek Old Testament to translate a Hebrew expression that means "set apart for God." In most cases, it has a negative meaning. It refers to something that is devoted to destruction as an offering to God (see Leviticus 27:28–29; Joshua 6:17–18; 7:1, 11–13; 22:20; 1 Samuel 15:3; 1 Chronicles 2:7).

Paul knows that he cannot actually be cut off from Christ. His words express deep sorrow and love, not a real possibility. Paul is echoing the words of Moses, who asked God to take his own life if that would spare the people of Israel (Exodus 32:30–32).

Romans 9:4

- Up to this point in Romans, Paul has called the Jewish people Jews. Here, and throughout most of 9–11, he shifts to the phrase the people of Israel. This change is important. Jew mainly points to national or ethnic identity. Israel emphasizes the special covenant relationship between the people and God.
- the adoption as sons: The Old Testament often calls Israel God's son or child. This language shows that God chose Israel to belong to him (for example, Exodus 4:22; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9; Hosea 11:1). Israel's adoption means that they received God's blessings and promises. It does not mean that every Israelite was automatically saved.
- covenants: A covenant is a formal and lasting agreement. In the Bible, a covenant is a binding relationship that God establishes with people. God promises to bless, protect, or guide them, and the people are called to trust God and live in obedience to him. God's covenants show his commitment to remain faithful to his people over time.

The Old Testament describes several covenants between God and the people of Israel. God made one covenant with Abraham (Genesis 17). He made another covenant with the nation through Moses at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19–24). God also made a covenant with David and his royal family (2 Samuel 7:8–16; 23:5).

Romans 9:5

Christ came from the people of Israel, and God first made his promises of salvation to them.

Romans 9:6

are Israel: The word Israel can have more than one meaning. It can refer to all the physical descendants of Jacob, that is, the people of Israel by birth. However, in the later part of the Old Testament and in Jewish teaching, a new idea developed. This idea is often called a "remnant," meaning a smaller group within Israel who remain faithful to God (see Isaiah 11:10–16).

In the New Testament, Israel can sometimes have a broader meaning. On at least one occasion, it refers to all people who belong to God in a spiritual sense, including both Jews and Gentiles (Galatians 6:16).

Paul teaches that there is now an "Israel within Israel." This means that not all who belong to Israel by birth truly belong to God's people. God's true people are those who believe, whether they are Jews or Gentiles (compare Romans 11:16–17; Galatians 6:16).

Romans 9:7

This quotation is from Genesis 21:12. God spoke these words to Abraham when he hesitated to follow Sarah's advice. She told him to send away his son Ishmael, who had been born to the slave woman Hagar.

God reassured Abraham that Isaac, Sarah's child, was the son through whom God would fulfill his promises.

Romans 9:10–11

twins were born: There were no human differences between Isaac's sons, Jacob and Esau. They were born to the same mother, and they were conceived at the same time. Nothing about their birth set one apart from the other.

Paul argues that the difference between them came from God's choice, not from human actions or circumstances.

Romans 9:12

"The older will serve the younger": God spoke these words to Rebekah before the twins were born (Genesis 25:23). Esau was the older twin, so he was Isaac's natural heir.

However, Esau sold his birthright to his brother Jacob. By doing this, Esau gave up his position as the firstborn. This action fulfilled what God had promised before the twins were born.

Romans 9:13

"Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated": Paul quotes Malachi 1:2–3. In that passage, Jacob, whose other name is Israel (Genesis 32:28). , represents the nation of Israel. Esau represents the nation of Edom.

Here in Romans, Paul speaks of Jacob and Esau as individuals. In the Bible, the word love can express choice or acceptance. In the same way, the word hate can express rejection rather than personal anger. Paul uses the story of Jacob and Esau to show that God, who rules over all things, chooses his people according to his own purpose.

Romans 9:14–16

God's choice is not unfair because God does not owe anything to sinful human beings (see study note on 4:4–5). Anything God gives is an act of mercy, not a payment that people deserve.

Romans 9:15

This quotation from Exodus 33:19 emphasizes God's nature. God is not obligated or forced to show mercy to anyone. When God shows mercy, he does so freely, according to his own will.

Romans 9:17

the Scripture says to Pharaoh: Following God's command, Moses commanded Pharaoh to let the Israelites leave Egypt for their own land (Exodus 9:16). Pharaoh stubbornly refused. In response, God performed many miracles. Through these acts, God showed his power and authority to Israel, to Pharaoh, and to the people of Egypt (see Exodus 6:7; 7:5; 9:14–16; 14:31).

Romans 9:18

He hardens whom He wants to harden: Pharaoh refused to let Israel leave because his heart became hard. A hard heart describes stubborn resistance to God. It means refusing to listen or change, even after seeing clear signs of God's power.

The book of Exodus says that God hardened Pharaoh's heart (Exodus 9:12). It also says that Pharaoh hardened his own heart (Exodus 8:15). Together, these statements show that Pharaoh was responsible for his actions, even as God carried out his purposes through Pharaoh's refusal.

Romans 9:20–21

See Isaiah 29:16 and Isaiah 45:9–10.

Romans 9:24–26

- God was free to choose some people from among the Jews to have a true spiritual relationship with him. In the same way, he was free to choose some people from among the Gentiles (non-Jewish people) to be saved. God was not limited by ethnic background.

Paul supports this point by quoting the prophet Hosea. Hosea spoke about the ten northern tribes of Israel. These tribes had rebelled against God and were under his judgment. Even so, Hosea said that God would show them mercy again.
Paul sees a wider principle in this prophecy. Just as

God renewed his mercy to disobedient Israelites, he can also show mercy to Gentiles.

- who are not My people: See study note on 10:19.

Romans 9:27–28

only the remnant will be saved: So many Israelites turned away from God that the Old Testament prophets spoke of a faithful group within the larger nation of Israel. This smaller group is often called a remnant (see Isaiah 11:10–16).

The remnant refers to those who remained loyal to God and trusted him. They would receive salvation. The rest of the people faced judgment because they continued to reject God.

Romans 9:29

The destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah shows the reality and seriousness of God's judgment (Genesis 19).

Romans 9:31

who pursued a law of righteousness: The phrase law of righteousness is an idiom. It means trying to become righteous by obeying the law. Paul is describing people who believed that careful law-keeping could put them in a right relationship with God.

Romans 9:32–33

a stone of stumbling and a rock of offense: This phrase means to fail to accept or understand something. In this context, it refers to people who reject or refuse to believe the message about Christ. Instead of trusting him, they turn away because his message challenges what they believe or expect.

Romans 9:33

This quotation is from Isaiah 8:14 and 28:16. These two texts, along with Psalm 118:22, are also quoted together in 1 Peter 2:6–8. The early church likely used a group of Old Testament passages about a "stone" to explain who Christ is and why he matters. These passages helped believers understand Christ's role in God's plan (see also Matthew 21:42).

Romans 10:2

zealous: This means a strong and sincere commitment to God and to what God desires (see Numbers 25:6–13). This kind of passion can be good and faithful.

In Paul's time, however, much Jewish zeal was misdirected. Many people did not understand that Jesus Christ is the central point of God's plan. Because of this, their passion did not lead them to the truth.

Paul points to his own life as an example. Before he trusted Christ, Paul showed great zeal, but it was aimed in the wrong direction (see Acts 9:1–2; Galatians 1:13–14)

Romans 10:3

God's righteousness: See 1:17; 3:21–26. Paul uses this phrase to explain Israel's failure using the core message of the gospel.

God showed his righteousness through the work of Jesus Christ. However, most Jews did not understand what God was doing. This was partly because they were focused on keeping the law as a way to establish their own righteousness, rather than trusting what God had done through Christ.

Romans 10:4

The function of the law was to point forward and prepare the way for the Messiah, God's chosen one. The coming of Jesus does not destroy the law but fulfills all of its requirements, so that the primary requirement for God's people is to believe in him (see 3:31; Matthew 5:17–18).

Romans 10:5

"The man who does these things will live by them": See Leviticus 18:5, where these words encouraged the Israelites to obey the law in order to enjoy long life and prosperity in the land that God was giving them (see also Leviticus 26:3–13; Deuteronomy 28:1–14). Paul explains that if people seek to be made right with God through the law, they must obey all of its commands, not just some of them.

Romans 10:6–8

Here, Paul quotes three phrases from Deuteronomy 30:12–14 dealing with the law, and he applies them to the good news about Jesus. We do not need to go up to heaven to find Jesus (and thus to be made right with God), because God has already brought him down to earth as a man. Nor do we need to go down to the place of the dead to find Jesus, because God has already raised him from the dead. To find Jesus, people must believe the message that God has made available to them.

Romans 10:13

Paul quotes Joel 2:32. In that passage, the LORD refers to Yahweh, the personal name of God (see Exodus

3:15). However, Romans 10:12 makes clear that the Lord in Romans refers to Jesus Christ. By applying this Old Testament passage to Jesus, Paul shows that believers from the time of the apostles understood Jesus to share in God's identity.

Romans 10:14

It is natural to think that the pronoun they refers to "all who call upon Him" from 10:12 or "everyone" from 10:13. This verse likely does refer to all people. However, it also continues Paul's criticism of Israel that began in 10:2–3 (see 10:18).

Paul argues that Israel was in a position to understand what God was doing through Jesus Christ. Because of this, Israel was responsible for failing to understand or accept God's work. Israel was guilty in two ways. First, they failed to understand God's plan after Christ came (10:3–4). Second, they focused so strongly on the law that they missed Christ when he arrived (9:30–32).

Romans 10:18

Indeed they did: Paul quotes Psalm 19:4 to show that the message of the good news about Jesus was available to all people through creation. In this sense, God had already made his message widely known.

By the time Paul wrote the book of Romans, early Christian messengers had spread the good news through much of the Roman Empire. Because of this, most Jews had many opportunities to hear the message.

Romans 10:19

make you jealous ... make you angry: This quotation from Deuteronomy 32:21 describes God's punishment of Israel for worshiping other gods (idolatry).

In Paul's time, Israel was still guilty of idolatry. This was because many people treated the law as more important than God himself. As a result, God used the Gentiles (people who were not even considered a nation) to make Israel jealous and angry. Paul explains this idea more fully in Romans 11:12–32.

Romans 10:20

This quotation is from Isaiah 65:1. In the book of Isaiah, the phrase "those who did not seek Me" refers to the people of Israel. As in Romans 9:25–26 Paul applies them to the Gentiles to show that God has made it possible for them to be a part of the people of God.

Romans 11:2

- whom He foreknew: Before the people of Israel could do anything to earn their place, God chose them to be his people. He did this because of his grace alone.
- Elijah: In 1 Kings 19:1–18, King Ahab had killed many of the Lord's prophets, and his wife Jezebel threatened to kill Elijah as well. Elijah ran into the wilderness and expressed his deep discouragement. God answered him by saying that many faithful people still remained.

Paul saw a similar situation in his own time. Many Jews did not believe, and some were even hostile to the message about Christ. Even so, God was still at work. He was, and is, preserving a remnant, a smaller group of people who believe.

Romans 11:5

a remnant: Paul refers back to the Old Testament idea of the remnant that he used in 9:27–29. A remnant refers to a small group of people who remain faithful when many others do not.

This faithful group of Israelites shows that God continues to keep his promises. It also shows that God remains faithful to his people.

Romans 11:7–8

The others were hardened: Scripture describes this hardening as something God allows or brings about as part of his judgment. God permits people to remain unresponsive when they persist in rejecting his message. See Acts 13:46–48; 18:6.

Romans 11:11

- salvation has come to the Gentiles: The offer of salvation to the Gentiles was not only the result of Israel's disobedience. It was also part of God's purpose. Paul stresses that God had the salvation of the Gentiles in view from the beginning. In the end, God also intends to bring salvation to many Jews.
- make Israel jealous: The idea of jealousy comes from Deuteronomy 32:21, which Paul quoted in Romans 10:19. When Gentiles received the blessings of salvation that God had promised to Israel, this was meant to encourage a desire among Jews. Seeing these blessings would move them to seek salvation so they could share in them.

Romans 11:13–14

- You Gentiles: Paul speaks directly to the gentile believers in Rome. His purpose is to correct them

for thinking too highly of themselves, especially when comparing themselves to their Jewish brothers and sisters (11:20). Paul reminds them that they enjoy salvation only because of God's kindness, not because of their own merit (11:22). He also explains that God's goal is not to reject the Jews. Instead, God intends to lead them to repentance and renewed faith (11:23).

- I magnify my ministry: Paul explains why he focused his work on the Gentiles. He believed that when Gentiles came to faith, this would help lead Jews to salvation as well. In this way, Paul saw his ministry to the Gentiles as part of God's larger plan to save both groups.

Romans 11:15

- The context emphasizes God's role in allowing many Jews to continue in their rejection of Christ (11:7–10). So the phrase their rejection likely refers to God's rejection of Jews who do not believe.
- their acceptance: This then refers to God's acceptance of Jews into his kingdom. Paul uses similar language elsewhere to describe God's welcoming action (see also 14:3 and 15:7).
- The phrase life from the dead could describe the new spiritual life Jews receive when they turn to Christ (see 6:13). However, the wording more naturally points to the bodily resurrection of the dead. This resurrection will take place when Christ returns in glory (see, for example, 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18).

Romans 11:16

The whole batch ... is holy: This is because the first part given as an offering is holy. This imagery comes from Numbers 15:17–21. In that passage, God told the Israelites to take part of their first batch of dough and set it apart as an offering to him.

Paul uses this image to explain God's faithfulness to Israel. God's promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob were like a first portion given to God. Because of these promises, God's work with his people will continue until it is complete.

Romans 11:17–24

In Paul's extended metaphor, God's special olive tree represents the people of God. This image would have been familiar to his readers. The olive tree was the most common fruit tree in the Mediterranean region. It was also already used as a symbol for Israel in the Old Testament (Jeremiah 11:16; Hosea 14:5–6).

Paul describes non-Jewish (gentile) Christians as branches from a wild olive tree because they were not originally part of God's people.

Romans 11:18

You do not support the root, but the root supports you: When Paul wrote to the church in Rome, most of its members were not Jewish. This was common in many early Christian communities.

Because Gentiles had become the majority, some began to boast about their place in God's people. Some also looked down on Jews and on Israel's religious heritage. Paul corrects this attitude. He reminds Gentile believers that they share in God's blessings only because they have been joined to God's people. That people is rooted in God's promises to Israel.

Romans 11:20

be afraid: In Scripture, fear often means deep respect and reverence for God. This kind of fear includes the awareness that all people will one day stand before God for judgment (see 2 Corinthians 5:11; 7:1, 11, 15; Philippians 2:12; Colossians 3:22).

Romans 11:22

if you continue in His kindness. Otherwise you also will be cut off: Scripture often teaches that those who remain faithful to the end will be saved. Paul's warning here has led to different views about what he means.

Some understand Paul to be saying that true believers can stop trusting God and therefore fail to be saved in the end. Others think Paul is using the image as a warning and should not be understood in a strict or literal way. From this view, Paul is speaking about people who appear to believe for a time, but whose lack of genuine faith later becomes clear.

Romans 11:24

contrary to nature: Farmers usually increased olive production by grafting a branch from a cultivated olive tree onto a wild olive tree. This allowed the cultivated branch to benefit from the strength of the wild tree.

Paul reverses this practice in his picture. God grafted branches from a wild olive tree (Gentiles) into a cultivated olive tree (the people of God). By doing this, God acted in a way that is opposite to normal farming practice.

Romans 11:25

Paul often uses the word mystery to describe an event at the end of history that God has already decided. This

mystery exists in heaven and God reveals it to his people during the Christian era (see 16:25; 1 Corinthians 2:1, 7; 4:1; 15:51; Ephesians 1:9; 3:3, 4, 9; 6:19; Colossians 1:26, 27; 2:2; 4:3; 1 Timothy 3:9, 16). Here, the mystery is the relationship of Jews and Gentiles in the plan of salvation, which is central to this passage (Romans 11:11–32).

Romans 11:26–27

- The phrase all Israel can be understood in more than one way. It may refer to all believers, both Jews and Gentiles. With this meaning, it describes how God brings salvation to all his people.

Another view is that all Israel refers to all Jews who will believe during the Christian era, or to a large number of Jews who turn to Christ in the last days. With this meaning, the word and so has a sequence. After the full number of Gentiles comes to Christ, then a large number of Jews will be saved. This phrase does not mean that every Jewish person will be saved(see 2:17–29).

- In the Old Testament, the one who rescues (or delivers) is the Lord. Paul is almost certainly speaking about Jesus Christ here (see 1 Thessalonians 1:10).
- from Zion: The Hebrew text of Isaiah 59:20 says, "The Redeemer will come to Jerusalem." Paul may have adjusted the wording to point to the first coming of Jesus from among the people of Israel. He may also be pointing to the future return of Jesus from the heavenly Jerusalem (see Hebrews 12:22).

Romans 11:32

may have mercy on everyone: Everyone refers to all kinds of people. In Paul's letter to the Romans, especially this chapter, it includes both Gentiles and Jews.

Romans 11:36

from Him and through Him and to Him are all things: This statement is similar to ideas found among Greek Stoic philosophers when they spoke about God. Paul sometimes used language and ideas from the Greco-Roman world to explain and clarify the truth about God and what God is doing.

Paul does this in other places as well, such as in his speech in Acts 17:24–29.

Romans 12:1

- Your bodies refers to the whole person as they live in the world, not only the physical body.
- on account of God's mercy: This refers to everything Paul explained in chapters 1–11.
- which is your spiritual service of worship (or which is your reasonable service): This phrase has at least three possible meanings:

1. Our sacrifices are reasonable considering all of God's acts of mercy.
2. Our sacrifices are spiritual, not the offering of an animal but of ourselves in spiritual service.
3. Our sacrifices are intelligent, offered with full awareness of God's goodness to us.

Romans 12:1–15.13

This section of Romans explains the moral and ethical demands of the gospel. God's gift of salvation in Christ calls for a response from believers.

God not only forgives sin. He also wants to transform how people live.

Much of what Paul teaches here about the moral duties of believers also appears in his other letters. However, Paul also addresses issues that were especially important for the church in Rome. One key issue was the disagreement between people who were weak in faith and people who were strong in faith(14:1–15:13).

Romans 12:2

this world (literally this age): Many Jewish people understood history as divided into two ages. One age is the present age, marked by sin and death. The other age is the age of salvation, when God puts things right.

Early Christians adopted this way of thinking. They understood the coming of Christ as the beginning of the new age of salvation.

However, the new age did not replace the old age right away. The old way of thinking and living continues. It still tempts believers, even those who want their lives to match the values of the new age.

Romans 12:3

according to the measure of faith God has given you: This phrase can also be translated by the standard of our God-given faith.

Paul may be referring to the amount of faith God has given to each person. He may also be referring to the shared Christian faith that all believers hold together.

In either case, Christians should judge themselves honestly by this measure. They should not become proud about the abilities God has given them.

Romans 12:4–5

so in Christ we who are many are one body: Paul compares the human body to the church, which he calls the body of Christ. He also uses this comparison in 1 Corinthians 12. This picture helps explain both unity and diversity in the church. Many parts belong to one body, and each part has an important role. Ancient writers also used this same comparison to describe how communities work together (compare Livy, History 2.32; Epictetus, Discourses 2.10.4–5).

Romans 12:6

- The ability to prophesy was one of the most important gifts in the New Testament (see also 1 Corinthians 12:28; Ephesians 4:11). Prophets in the book of Acts often predicted the future (see Acts 11:28; 21:10–12). But their main role was to share God's message with Christians (1 Corinthians 12:3, 24–25, 29–30; see also 1 Corinthians 14:1–40).
- in proportion to his faith: The word proportion (Greek analogia) comes from mathematics and logic. It refers to a proper relationship between things, amounts, or ideas.

Paul uses this phrase to remind prophets to speak in a way that matches faith. This may refer to the amount of faith God has given to the prophet. It may also refer to the shared Christian faith held by all believers (see study note on Romans 12:3).
This passage later became the basis for the theological phrase the analogy of faith. This phrase means that any one part of Scripture should be understood in a way that agrees with the teaching of all of Scripture.

Romans 12:7

teaching: The gift of teaching is listed third among the gifts in 1 Corinthians 12:28 and fifth in Ephesians 4:11. Prophets speak to the community with a message they receive directly from God. Teachers, however, instruct the church by carefully studying the word of God and explaining it to others.

Romans 12:8

give generously: See also 2 Corinthians 8:2; 9:11, 13.

Romans 12:9–21

The many instructions in these verses are not arranged in a strict or orderly pattern. The main theme, stated at the beginning, is sincere love.

Paul explains how believers should show love to people inside the church (12:10, 13, 15–16). He also explains how they should show love to people outside the church (12:14, 17–21).

Romans 12:10

brotherly love: This phrase describes the love that exists within a family. Christians are to love one another with the same care, loyalty, and commitment found in a healthy family.

Romans 12:11

keep your spiritual fervor, serving the Lord: This means a deep commitment to God that motivates a person to serve faithfully and actively. Christians should eagerly serve the Lord by caring for and supporting others within the church.

Romans 12:12

The three commands in this verse are closely connected. When believers rejoice in confident hope, they are able to remain patient during trouble.

Continual prayer is essential for maintaining this attitude when facing the difficulties of life (see also 8:24–27).

Romans 12:13

Share with the saints who are in need: The verb Paul uses is related to the Greek word koinōnia, which means "sharing" or "fellowship."

When fellow believers have needs, Christians should do more than give material help. They should also share life together, showing care, relationship, and mutual support that go beyond gifts alone.

Romans 12:14

The instructions in this verse closely match two teachings of Jesus (Matthew 5:44; Luke 6:27–28). Paul does not present these commands as direct quotations. However, he is almost certainly referring to the words of Christ.

These teachings may have been so well known that Paul did not need to name their source. Many ideas in Romans 12–13 closely reflect the teaching of Jesus.

Romans 12:16

- All three instructions in this verse use the Greek word phroneō, which means "to think." Paul emphasizes the importance of right Christian thinking in relationships with other believers.

- Live in harmony: Literally think the same things. This means to share a common attitude and purpose, not to have identical opinions.
- Do not be conceited: Literally do not think arrogant things. This means not viewing oneself as better than others.

Romans 12:18

If it is possible on your part: Paul understands that efforts to live at peace with others do not always succeed. Sometimes faithfulness to what is right limits what we can do. At other times, other people may refuse to be reconciled.

Romans 12:20–21

A simple act of Christian kindness can often bring a hostile person to repentance before God and restore fellowship between people.

Romans 13:1–2

- The main command in 13:1–7 is to submit to governing authorities. In God's ordering of the world, people are accountable to those who hold positions of authority. This submission usually takes the form of obedience.

However, God stands above all governments. For this reason, submission to governing authorities is always shaped by our ultimate obedience to God (see Acts 4:19–20).

Some Christians in Rome may have been resisting the government. They may have misunderstood the good news, thinking that no longer copying the values of this world (12:2) meant they could ignore earthly authorities (see study note on Rom 13:6).

- God has set in place: Scripture consistently teaches that God is active in raising up and bringing down human leaders and governments (1 Samuel 2:6–10; 12:8; Proverbs 8:15–16; Isaiah 41:2–4; 45:1–7; Jeremiah 21:7, 10; 27:5–6; Daniel 2:21, 37–38; 4:17).

Because God has ordered human society through governing authorities, rejecting their role entirely is a rejection of God's ordering of the world. At the same time, obedience to rulers is never absolute. When rulers demand what conflicts with obedience to God, faithfulness to God must come first (Acts 4:19–20; Romans 13:2).

Romans 13:3

rulers are not a terror to good conduct: Paul presents a positive picture of governing authorities. He describes them according to the role God has given them. Paul does not discuss situations where rulers punish those who do good and reward those who do evil.

Paul was aware of such situations. He knew them from the Old Testament and Jewish history, from the experience of Jesus and the other apostles, and from events in the Greco-Roman world. Here, Paul limits his discussion to how believers should respond to governing authorities who act according to their calling.

Romans 13:4

- Servant: The New Testament often uses this Greek word (diakonos) to describe Christians serving God in different roles. In non-religious Greek, diakonos can also refer to a city official. A government and its leaders serve God by administering justice, whether they realize it or not.
- he does not carry the sword in vain: Here, the sword might be a metaphor for any punishment. Some interpreters believe it means human governments, under God's authority, have the right to use capital punishment. (Capital punishment is the practice of killing someone as a legal penalty for certain crimes.)

Romans 13:5

- These two reasons for submission summarize 13:1–4. in reverse order. The reason to avoid punishment connects to 13:3–4. The matter of conscience connects to 13:1–2.
- The word conscience (Greek suneidēsis) refers here to the painful awareness of doing wrong. Christians know that they have a duty to submit to governing authorities. If they fail to do so, they would experience the pain of a guilty conscience.

Romans 13:6

pay taxes: Jesus spoke about paying taxes in his well-known teaching on the disciples' relationship to government (Matthew 22:21). A tax revolt took place in Rome around the time Paul was writing this letter. Paul may have known about this event. His discussion of the Christian responsibility toward government may have been prompted by reports that some Roman Christians were involved in this revolt (see Tacitus, Annals 13).

Romans 13:8

- The idea of obligation connects 13:1–7 and 13:8–10. Christians should "pay everyone what you owe him" (13:7). At the same time, Christians always owe love to their neighbors.

- Be indebted to no one: Debt is not wrong, but Christians should avoid it. If a Christian does incur debt, it should be repaid promptly. This allows the believer to remain free to serve others in love (see Proverbs 22:7).
- to one another in love: Christians are called to love all people they encounter (Romans 12:14–21; Luke 10:25–37). However, this phrase especially emphasizes the love that each Christian owes to other Christians.
- has fulfilled the law: This teaching closely follows the teaching of Jesus in Matthew 22:34–40.

Romans 13:8–10

These verses explain how Christians should treat other people. True love for others will be shown through actions that follow God's commandments about human relationships.

Romans 13:11

The New Testament often speaks of salvation as the final victory over sin and death that those who believe in Jesus will experience when Jesus returns in glory (see 5:9–10).

Romans 13:12–13

the day has drawn near: The word day comes from two sources:

- First, the Old Testament repeatedly predicts the Day of the LORD. This is the time when God brings his plan to its completion (see Isaiah 13:4–13; Jeremiah 3:18; 30:8–9; Joel 2:1–32; Obadiah 1:15–18).
- Second, moral teaching in the ancient world often used day and light to represent what is good. Night and darkness represented what is evil. Greeks, Romans, and Jews all used this contrast.

Because believers belong to the day, they should live according to its values. This means avoiding the dark actions that are associated with nighttime.

Romans 14:1

whose faith is weak: This means having a sensitive conscience about doing certain things that Christian freedom would allow.

In Rome, most believers who were weak in faith were Jewish Christians. Their consciences did not allow them freedom from some practices required by the Jewish law.

Romans 14:1–15.7

Paul addresses a specific issue causing conflict in the church at Rome. The church encountered a dispute between those weak in faith and those strong in faith about certain practices (see 15:1).

Throughout this section, Paul urges Christians to show patience and tolerance toward one another and their practices. He is convinced that people on both sides are genuine believers. He also believes that the issues they are arguing about are not essential to the Christian faith.

Romans 14:2

The weak in faith apparently believed that they should eat only vegetables. This belief likely came from a desire to maintain Jewish ritual purity while living in a pagan culture.

These Jewish Christians were following an example found in the book of Daniel. Daniel and his friends refused the rich food and wine offered by the king of Babylon (Daniel 1:3–16).

Other Jewish writings show a similar concern. Devout Jews living in pagan cultures often limited their diet because they could not be sure that meat had been prepared according to Jewish requirements.

Romans 14:3–4

- belittle ... judge: The "strong," who took pride in their freedom in Christ, looked down on those they considered to be weak. The weak, in turn, believed they were following the true path of faith. Because of this, they judged the strong for being too careless in their behavior.

Similar attitudes have appeared many times throughout the history of the Christian church. Christians have often argued over different practices and judged one another in the same way.

- God has accepted him: Both "the weak" and "the strong" are true Christians. God has welcomed them into his family. For this reason, they have no right to treat one another as if they do not belong (14:4; see also 15:7).

Romans 14:5

One person regards a certain day above the others, while someone else considers every day alike: The reference is probably to Jewish festival days and to the Sabbath (compare Colossians 2:16). Because Christ has provided salvation, Christians are no longer required to observe the Sabbath in its original form.

Romans 14:7

As servants of the Lord, Christians should seek guidance from God and seek to honor him in all things (14:4, 8). Because we are ultimately accountable to him, our desire should always be to please him, not to live for ourselves.

Romans 14:9

- Paul refers to standard early Christian teaching on the significance of the death and resurrection of Jesus (for example, 2 Corinthians 5:15).
- of both the dead and of the living: The original word order matches the sequence of the death and resurrection of Jesus, the redemptive events that make Jesus our Lord.

Romans 14:10

we will all stand before God's judgment seat: Paul reminds the Roman Christians that it is the Lord, not other Christians, who will ultimately judge all of us (compare 2 Corinthians 5:10).

Romans 14:11

This quotation is from Isaiah 49:18; 45:23. In its original context, Isaiah 45:23 appears among strong statements about God's sovereignty (Isaiah 45:22, 24). Sovereign means having the highest authority and complete power. When God is described as sovereign, it means that God rules over all things. Because God alone is sovereign, only he has the right to judge. For this reason, believers should not judge one another (Romans 14:10, 12).

Romans 14:13

- This verse serves as a bridge between two sections. The call to stop judging one another summarizes 14:1–12. The warning about causing another believer to stumble becomes the main focus of 14:14–23.
- stumbling block or obstacle: This phrase originally described objects that could trip someone while walking, or traps into which a person might fall. In the New Testament, it is often used in a figurative way. It refers to behavior that may cause spiritual harm to another person (see 1 Corinthians 8:9, 13; 1 John 2:10; compare Matthew 21:42–44; Luke 20:17–18; Romans 9:32–33; 1 Peter 2:8).

Romans 14:14

- nothing is unclean in itself (literally, nothing is common in itself): The word common shows that Paul is addressing Jewish purity rules. Jews described food as common if it was not clean, meaning it was not kosher. Eating such food would make a person ritually impure (see Leviticus 11; compare Mark 7:2, 5; Acts 10:14). Paul's teaching is consistent with the instruction from Jesus that food does not make a person unclean (Mark 7:19).
- for him it is unclean: The teaching that no food is wrong to eat was difficult for devout Jews to accept. They had been raised to honor God by avoiding certain foods. Paul therefore urges believers who are strong in faith not to pressure others to act against their conscience (compare 1 Corinthians 8:1–13).

Romans 14:15

The word translated as destroy (from the Greek apollumi) often used to describe eternal judgment (see 2:12; Matthew 10:28; 18:14; Luke 9:24; 13:2–5; John 3:16; 10:10, 28; 1 Corinthians 1:18–19; James 4:12; 2 Peter 3:9). By insisting on their freedom to eat any food, believers who were strong in faith could harm others. They might cause sensitive Jewish Christians, for whom Christ died, to turn away from the faith.

Romans 14:20

The work of God involves both the spiritual life of other Christians and to the Christian community itself (14:15, 19). When the strong insist on doing whatever they want, they cause division. This behavior goes against God's purpose to build a healthy and united community of believers.

Romans 14:21

or drink wine: Some Jews chose not to drink wine to avoid appearing ritually unclean. Wine was often used in pagan religious ceremonies, which could make its use seem improper (see Daniel 1:3–16).

Romans 14:22

- Keep your belief about such matters between yourself and God: Paul did not deny the freedom of the strong believers. However, he told them to limit how they show that freedom. They should do this out of love for other believers, so the whole Christian community can be strengthened.
- Blessed is the one who does not condemn himself: Guilt can result from harming the faith of weaker believers. Christian freedom has value only when it can be practiced without causing this kind of guilt.

Romans 14:23

everything that is not from faith is sin: God's word teaches us what sin is. Sin also includes acting against one's conscience (our inner sense of right and wrong).

Some Christians in Rome did not yet believe they could eat meat, drink wine, or ignore Jewish holy days. Their consciences were still weak. They should not act against their consciences in these matters. The strong should also not pressure them to do so, either by their example or by showing contempt.

Romans 15:1–4

- We who are strong: Paul includes himself among those he calls strong in faith. This shows that the division in the Roman church was not simply between Jews and Gentiles. Like Paul, some Jews had informed consciences and were counted among the strong. In the same way, some Gentiles were deeply influenced by Jewish teaching and tradition and were counted among the weak in faith.
- ought to bear with the shortcomings of the weak: This idea is similar to Galatians 6:2. Paul did not want the strong merely to tolerate those who were weak in faith. Instead, the strong were to help them actively and with care, so the weak could live out their Christian faith with integrity (see also Galatians 5:13–15).

Romans 15:2

his neighbor: See Leviticus 19:18, quoted in Romans 13:9. Love for others should guide how Christians who are strong in faith live and act.

Romans 15:3

- This quotation is from Psalm 69:9.
- Several passages in the New Testament use Psalm 69 to describe the suffering of Jesus (Matthew 27:34; Mark 15:35–36; Luke 23:36; John 15:25; 19:28–29). By quoting only part of this psalm, Paul reminds people of the full story of the suffering of Jesus, not just one moment.

Romans 15:4

For everything that was written in the past was written for our instruction: God caused everything in the Scriptures to be written for his purposes, to teach believers.

Romans 15:5–6

grant you harmony with one another: This phrase refers to a person's overall way of thinking (see study note on 12:16). A shared way of thinking is essential for unity among Christians (see 12:3–5, 16; Philippians 2:2–5).

Romans 15:7

accept one another: This means more than just tolerating one another. We should welcome other Christians, with all their flaws and sins, into our community and treat them as family (see study note on 12:10). Christ has done that very thing for us (5:8–11).

Romans 15:8–9

Through Christ, God enabled Jews and Gentiles to unite and glorify him as the new covenant people of God (see chapters 9–11). The issue of Jewish and Gentile relationships was central to the disagreement in the Roman church (14:1–15:7).

Romans 15:9–12

so that the Gentiles may glorify God for His mercy: Gentiles are now full members of God's people.

Romans 15:14

brimming with knowledge: Paul praises the Roman Christians, as he had in the beginning of the letter (see 1:8–12). This shows his gracious attitude toward a church that he had not founded and had not yet visited.

Romans 15:14–16.27

This final section includes elements often found at the end of New Testament letters:

- a discussion of travel plans (15:14–29),
- requests for prayer (15:30–33),
- references to ministry partners (16:1–2, 21–23),
- greetings (16:3–16), and
- a short hymn of praise (16:25–27).

Only the warning about false teachers is a non-standard feature in this conclusion (16:17–19).

Romans 15:15–16

the grace God has given me: Paul emphasized that his role as apostle and teacher was because God had chosen him to lead in the formation of the Christian church (see also 1:5; 12:3; 1 Corinthians 3:10; Galatians 2:9; Ephesians 3:2, 7, 8).

Romans 15:16

- a minister: The Greek word leitourgos means "servant" or "minister." It can describe many kinds of service, but Jews often used it for priests. Paul likely chose this word to highlight the priestly nature of his work.
- so that the Gentiles: Paul emphasizes that the church in Rome included many Gentiles (see also

1:6–7). This does not mean there were no Jews in the church, but Gentiles had become the majority (see 16:3–16).
- become an offering acceptable to God: Paul was fulfilling Isaiah 66:19–20.

Romans 15:19

- I have fully proclaimed the gospel of Christ: Paul was not saying that the work of sharing the gospel was finished in these regions. He meant that churches had been planted in enough major cities. These churches could now continue the work themselves. Paul's own role of starting key and foundational churches had been completed.
- from Jerusalem all the way around to Illyricum: This description covers the regions where Paul had planted churches, including southern Galatia, Asia Minor, Macedonia, and Greece. Illyricum was a Roman province along the Adriatic Sea. It lay northeast of Italy, in the area of modern-day Albania and Croatia.

Romans 15:24

- I hope to see you on my way to Spain: In Paul's time, "Spain" referred to the whole Iberian Peninsula, which includes modern Spain and Portugal. The Romans had controlled parts of this region since 200 BC. However, it became an organized Roman province only during Paul's lifetime. Paul viewed Spain, at the western edge of the Mediterranean world, as the final stage of his mission. Through this mission, he believed he was fulfilling Isaiah 66:19–20.
- you can equip me for my journey: Spain was very far from Paul's earlier sending church in Antioch of Syria. For this reason, Paul hoped the church in Rome could support him and serve as a base for this future work.

Romans 15:25–28

I am on my way to Jerusalem to serve the saints there: During his third mission journey, Paul gathered donations from the Gentile churches. This was to help the Christians in Jerusalem and to unite the two groups of the first-century AD church (see also 1 Corinthians 16:1–2; 2 Corinthians 8–9).

Romans 15:26

- Paul started churches in several major cities in Macedonia, including Philippi, Thessalonica, and Berea. In Achaia, Paul preached in Athens and started the church in Corinth (see Acts 16–18).
- the poor among the saints in Jerusalem: Jewish Christians in Jerusalem were starving because of droughts in the area (see Acts 11:27–30). Their faith in Christ also led to their exclusion from Jewish society.

Romans 15:27

indeed they owe it to them: Gentile Christians owe their spiritual existence to God's work among the Israelites (see 11:17–24).

Romans 15:31

Pray that I may be delivered from the unbelievers in Judea: See Acts 21–22. God saved the apostle Paul's life and used his arrest in Jerusalem to guide him to Rome, where he intended to go.

Romans 15:33

Some manuscripts do not include the word Amen. One very early manuscript places the doxology (a short hymn of praise, 16:25–27) here. This has led some scholars to think that the original letter to the Romans included only 1:1–15:33. However, few scholars now support this theory. The best early manuscripts place the doxology at the end of chapter 16. Most likely, all of chapter 16 was part of Paul's original letter to the Romans. See also the study note on 16:1–16.

Romans 16:1

- a servant: The Greek word diakonos means "servant." It can refer in a general way to a believer who serves Christ. It can also refer more specifically to someone who holds the recognized role of deacon in a local church (see Philippians 1:1; 1 Timothy 3:8–12; compare Acts 6:1–6).
- Cenchrea was about eight kilometers (five miles) from Corinth and served as its port. Paul may have written this letter to the Romans while staying in Corinth during the winter, near the end of his third missionary journey (see Acts 20:2–3).

Romans 16:1–16

Paul greeted twenty-seven Christians in Rome, ten of whom were women. This shows that women played important roles in the early church.

Paul had not yet visited Rome. This has led some people to wonder how he knew so many Christians there. One idea is that chapter 16 was part of a different letter that Paul sent to Ephesus. However, there is no strong manuscript evidence for a separate letter (see study note on 15:33). A more likely explanation is that Paul met these Christians while they were trav-

eling outside Rome (see Romans Book Introduction, "Setting").

Romans 16:2

she has been a great help to many people: This phrase refers to the ancient role of a patron. A patron was a wealthy person who used influence and money to support people and important work. Phoebe appears to have been a woman of wealth and influence who used her resources to support missionaries, including Paul.

Romans 16:3

Priscilla and Aquila were Paul's good friends. After leaving Rome around AD 49, they became his co-workers for an extended time in Corinth and Ephesus (see Acts 18–19). They had apparently returned to Rome by the time Paul wrote Romans (about AD 57).

Romans 16:3–16

Although Paul had not yet visited the Christian community in Rome, he built a relationship with these believers by greeting many of them by name. The names show that the Roman church was very diverse. Jews and Gentiles, enslaved people and free people, men and women all formed a new community in the church (see Galatians 3:26–29).

Romans 16:5

the church that meets at their house: Early Christians did not have large buildings for their meetings. Instead, they met in private homes. The church in Rome was made up of a number of house churches where small groups of believers gathered for worship and instruction.

Romans 16:7

- In Greek, the name Junia can refer either to a man named Junias or to a woman named Junia. Most interpreters understand it as a woman's name. In this section, Paul often lists men and women together as husband-and-wife teams. For this reason, Junia was most likely a woman.
- fellow prisoners: We do not know when this happened. The book of Acts reports that Paul was imprisoned overnight in Philippi (Acts 16:19–28). After Paul wrote Romans, he was imprisoned for two years in Caesarea and for two years in Rome (Acts 24:27; 28:30–31). Paul also mentions other imprisonments that Acts does not record (see 2 Corinthians 11:23).
- They are outstanding among the apostles: This phrase most likely means that Andronicus and Junia were apostles. Here, apostles refers to recognized missionaries sent by the church (see Acts 14:4, 14; 1 Corinthians 9:5–6; Galatians 2:9).

Romans 16:10

This Aristobulus was probably the same person as the brother of Herod Agrippa I. Aristobulus belonged to the Roman ruling class and lived in Rome for many years before his death around AD 48 or 49 (see Josephus, Antiquities 18.8.4; War 2.11.6). The phrase the household of Aristobulus most likely refers to his family members and their servants who lived in Rome.

Romans 16:13

This Rufus might be the son of Simon of Cyrene, who carried the cross of Christ (see Mark 15:21).

Romans 16:16

with a holy kiss: The kiss was a common way to greet another person in the ancient world and particularly among the Jews. It is mentioned frequently in the New Testament as a greeting (1 Corinthians 16:20; 2 Corinthians 13:12; 1 Thessalonians 5:26; see 1 Peter 5:14). By the second century AD, the kiss of peace became a regular part of Christian worship.

Romans 16:17

those who create divisions: Paul had faced problems with false teachers who caused division in other churches (see Galatians, Colossians, 1 Timothy). Because of this, he warned the church in Rome about the same danger.

Romans 16:20

The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet: Paul refers to God's judgment on the serpent after it deceived Adam and Eve in the garden of Eden (Genesis 3:15). Christ, the promised descendant of Eve, will defeat Satan. This victory will be shared with the church, which stands under Christ's authority (compare Matthew 16:18–19).

Romans 16:21

Timothy was one of Paul's closest coworkers in ministry. He traveled with Paul on the second missionary journey (Acts 16:2–3). Timothy was also with Paul in Corinth when Paul wrote this letter to the church in Rome (see Acts 20:2–4).

Romans 16:22

Tertius was the scribe (or amanuensis) who wrote the letter as Paul dictated. Most ancient letter writers employed such a scribe.

Romans 16:23

This Erastus was probably the individual Paul sent from Ephesus to Macedonia during his third missionary journey (Acts 19:21–22; see 2 Timothy 4:20). An inscription found in Corinth mentions a man named Erastus who served as a city official. He may be the same Erastus mentioned here.

Romans 16:25

the mystery: For Paul, a mystery is a truth about God and his plan that was not clearly known in the time of the Old Testament. God has now made this plan known in the time of the New Testament. The Old Testament foretold that Gentiles would turn to God. However, it did not clearly show that Gentiles would become equal members of God's people without first becoming converts to Judaism.

Romans 16:25–27

- This doxology (a short hymn of praise) provides a fitting conclusion to Paul's letter and its message. It brings together many of the same themes found at the beginning of the letter (1:1–15).
- The doxology is missing from two later manuscripts and appears in different places in some others, such as after 14:23 or after 15:33. Because of this, some have suggested that these verses were added later. However, most manuscripts place the doxology at the end of the letter. Its language and themes also match the rest of Romans. For these reasons, Paul most likely wrote it himself as the letter's conclusion.

Romans 16:26

the obedience that comes from faith: Paul uses the same language about the mission to the Gentiles that he used in 1:5. This repetition forms a clear frame around the whole letter.